

GOP SPLITS OVER HEALTH SUBSIDY

Four Republicans side with Democrats in forcing House vote on tax credit extension.

BY ANA CEBALLOS AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Four House Republicans broke with party leadership on Wednesday to join Democrats in overriding the GOP majority and forcing a vote on extending healthcare tax credits — a defection that underscores the party’s growing vulnerability on economic issues ahead of next year’s midterm elections.

The healthcare tax credits, which were central to the fight that led to the longest government shutdown in U.S. history, are set to expire at the end of the year unless Congress takes action.

Democrats, and a small but increasingly vocal group of Republicans, warned that allowing the tax credits to lapse would lead to sharp healthcare premium increases for millions of Americans, which could prove a politically perilous outcome in competitive districts.

House Republicans, including Speaker Mike Johnson (R-La.), have resisted extending the tax credits, arguing instead for an alternative approach to lowering healthcare costs. But that stance on Wednesday showed that they were at odds with members who say the issue would hurt constituents.

“I’m pissed for the American people,” Rep. Mike Lawler (R-N.Y.) told reporters.

His remarks came after he joined Republican Reps. Brian Fitzpatrick, Robert Bresnahan and Ryan MacKenzie, all from Pennsylvania, in signing a Democrat-led petition that needed 218 signatures to force a floor vote on a bill to extend the healthcare subsidies for three years. The four Republicans were the final votes needed.

California Rep. Kevin Kiley (R-Rocklin), who represents a swing district, was not among the Republicans to sign the petition, but he told reporters it is important for leadership to take up the matter sooner than later. Otherwise, he said, it would be a “failure of leadership.”

“We have members on [See Healthcare, A6]



DEFENSE attorney Alan Jackson arrives outside L.A. County Superior Court where Nick Reiner appeared.

Nick Reiner in court to face charges

Defense attorney warns against ‘rush to judgment’ in celebrity couple’s murder case.

BY JAMES QUEALLY, RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

Nick Reiner made his first appearance in a Los Angeles courtroom on Wednesday morning, roughly three days after allegedly killing his parents — beloved Hollywood figures Rob Reiner and Michele Singer Reiner — inside their Brentwood home.

Flanked by his attorney, Alan Jackson, and two other lawyers, Reiner was barely visible from the courtroom gallery during the brief hearing. He wore a blue suicide prevention smock frequently given to defendants who pose a risk of self-harm.

Reiner, 32, was charged with two counts of murder on Tuesday and could face life in prison or the death penalty if convicted. Los Angeles County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman said that no decision had been made on seeking capital punishment in the Reiners’ slayings. Such reviews normally take months.

A judge approved Jackson’s request Wednesday to continue Reiner’s arraignment to Jan. 7. He did not enter a plea.

“There are very very complex, serious issues associated with this case,” that need to be analyzed, Jackson told reporters outside the courthouse after the hearing. Jackson did not answer any questions as reporters probed him about his client’s mental health and asked who was paying for his legal services.

“We ask that during this process you allow the system to move forward in the way it was designed. Not with a rush to judgment. Not with jumping to conclusions. But with restraint and with dignity,” he said.

Reiner will continue to be held in Los Angeles County jail without bail.

Prosecutors allege Reiner fatally stabbed his 78-year-old father and 70-year-old mother sometime in the early morning hours on Sunday. Their bodies were found in the master bedroom of their home around 3:40 p.m., authorities have said.

A massage therapist arrived at the couple’s home and, upon not receiving an [See Reiner, A6]

And the Oscars go to ... YouTube

Hollywood’s biggest night is moving to YouTube.

Beginning in 2029, the Oscars will stream live and free worldwide on the video platform under a new multi-year agreement between the Academy of Motion Picture Arts and Sciences and YouTube, a major shift for an awards show long synonymous with broadcast television and a clear signal of how entertainment consumption has changed.

The deal, announced Wednesday, gives YouTube exclusive global rights to the Academy Awards starting with the 101st ceremony in 2029 and running through 2033 — ending a five-decade partnership with ABC and making the Oscars the most prominent entertainment awards show to abandon a major broadcast network in favor of a digital-first platform. The show, including red carpet coverage and behind-the-scenes access, will

Awards ceremony will stream in 2029, ending broadcast TV run

BY JOSH ROTTENBERG AND STEPHEN BATTAGLIO



ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times JULIANNE HOUGH attends the 97th Academy Awards in March. The 100th will be the last on ABC.

stream live on YouTube around the world, with U.S. viewers also able to watch via YouTube TV.

For the Oscars, which have struggled with declining viewership and cultural impact since their ratings peak in the mid-1990s, the move to YouTube offers the potential to reach a far wider audience than it could on any broadcast network. The 2025 telecast, hosted by Conan O’Brien, attracted roughly 19.7 million viewers across ABC and digital platforms — an uptick from the previous year but still a fraction of the 40-plus million who watched in the 1990s and early 2000s.

This trend has been mirrored across awards shows as broadcast viewership declines and fans increasingly turn to streaming and clips on social media. YouTube counts more than 2 billion logged-in users monthly and [See Oscars, A10]

Paramount’s hostile offer rejected

Warner Bros. accuses the Ellison family of not putting money behind takeover bid.

BY MEG JAMES

Warner Bros. Discovery has sharply rejected Paramount’s hostile offer, alleging the \$108-billion deal carries substantial risks because the Larry Ellison family has failed to put real money behind its bid for Warner’s legendary movie studio, HBO and CNN.

Paramount “has consistently misled WBD shareholders that its proposed

transaction has a ‘full backstop’ from the Ellison family,” Warner Bros. Discovery’s board wrote Wednesday in a letter to its shareholders filed with the Securities and Exchange Commission.

“It does not, and never has,” the Warner board said.

Warner’s board voted unanimously to reject Paramount’s hostile bid, concluding it was not in the best interests of shareholders.

For Warner, what was missing was a clear declaration from Paramount that the Ellison family had agreed to commit funding for the deal. Paramount last week told Warner stockholders that it would pay them

\$30 a share — or \$78 billion for the entire company. Paramount also has said it would absorb Warner’s debt, making the overall deal valued at \$108 billion.

Paramount disputed Warner’s contention that the Ellison family had not come through with needed financial guarantees.

“We remain committed to bringing together two iconic Hollywood studios to create a unique global entertainment leader,” Paramount Chair and Chief Executive David Ellison said Wednesday, reaffirming Paramount’s strategy to take its case directly to Warner shareholders.

“We will continue to move

forward to deliver this transaction, which is in the best interest of WBD shareholders, consumers and the creative industries,” Ellison said.

The Warner auction has taken several nasty turns since Warner board members on Dec. 4 unanimously approved Netflix’s \$82.7-billion deal for the Warner Bros. film and television studios, HBO and HBO Max.

In its letter, the Warner board reaffirmed its support for Netflix’s \$27.75 a share proposal, saying it represented the best deal for shareholders. Warner board members urged investors not to tender their shares to [See Paramount, A11]

Vise tightens on Venezuela

Trump’s partial blockade, claims of stolen resources raise tensions

BY PATRICK J. McDONNELL, ANA CEBALLOS AND KATE LINTHICUM



BRENDAN SMIALOWSKI AFP/Getty Images THE PRESIDENT said the U.S. will be “getting land, oil rights and whatever we had” from Venezuela.

MEXICO CITY — President Trump’s order of a partial blockade on oil tankers going to and from Venezuela and his claim that Caracas stole “oil, land and other assets” from the United States mark a significant escalation of Washington’s unrelenting campaign against the government of President Nicolás Maduro.

Asked about Venezuela on Wednesday, Trump said the United States will be “getting land, oil rights and whatever we had.”

“We want it back,” he said without further elaboration. It was unclear whether Trump planned to say more about Venezuela in a televised address to the nation late Wednesday night.

The blockade, which aims to cripple the key component of Venezuela’s faltering, oil-dependent economy, comes as the Trump administration has bolstered military forces in the Caribbean. [See Venezuela, A4]

Climate center to be dismantled

The Trump administration moves to break up a renowned research institution in Colorado. NATION, A14

Eaton survivors seek housing aid

Residents displaced by the Jan. 7 fire call on Edison to provide emergency relief. BUSINESS, A9

A showdown for West supremacy

Rams travel to Seattle to take on Seahawks in a battle for NFC’s top seed and division title. SPORTS, B10

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 76/50. B6

Markets A11 Opinion Voices A12

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U.S. economy was stagnant but for AI

Billions invested by California-based firms made up 92% of GDP growth, analysis finds.

BY MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Today’s political consensus crosses all ages, demographics and party lines: Three out of four Americans think the economy is in a slump. It is not just in their heads. Economic growth this year has been practically stagnant, save for one exception, economists say.

Hundreds of billions of dollars invested by California-based tech giants in artificial intelligence infrastructure accounted for 92% of the nation’s GDP growth this year, according to a Harvard analysis, supported by other independent economic studies.

It is a remarkable boon

for a handful of companies that could lay the groundwork for future U.S. economic leadership. But, so far, little evidence exists that their ventures are expanding opportunities for everyday Americans.

“You have to watch out for AI investments — they may continue to carry the economy or they may slow down or crash, bringing the rest of the economy together with them,” said Daron Acemoglu, an economics professor at MIT. “We are not seeing much broad-based productivity improvements from AI or other innovations in the economy, because if we were, we would see productivity growth and investment picking up the rest of the economy as well.”

Even in California itself, where four of the top five AI companies are based, the AI boom has yet to translate into tangible pocketbook benefits. On the contrary, [See Economy, A6]